serve as the initial proof of accountability that will later support compliance and assurance frameworks.

Organizations that start with small, observable practices—such as documenting decisions, assigning ownership, and using version control—lay the foundation for mature governance later. You don’t need ACME’s full framework to start; you just need consistent ways to connect intention, action, and accountability.

14.7 Governance as the foundation of trust

At ACME, policy governance reshaped authorization from a technical subsystem into a management discipline that spanned the entire organization. The company’s early experience with fragmented policies and redundant logic made it clear that access control couldn't be fixed by better tools alone. Instead, it needed a framework for ownership, accountability, and continuous learning. The implementation of ADRs established that foundation. Every update to a policy or template included a clear explanation of the reason, enabling everyone—from engineers to auditors—to understand not just what changed but why. Over time, those ADRs evolved into a living record of ACME’s authorization intent.

The Access Control Coordinating Council provided governance with a dedicated home. What started as an informal working group grew into a cross-functional council that connects engineering, operations, compliance, and product leadership. The council’s monthly policy review meetings link the proactive and reactive aspects of governance: approving new policies, examining incidents where access control was a factor, and making sure that every operational lesson found its way back into the design process. The outcome is a culture where policy is not an afterthought but a core part of the engineering workflow.

Integration with Identity Governance and Administration (IGA) unified the identity aspect of access management. The ACCC started using IGA data to verify policy assumptions by comparing the entitlements in IGA with the conditions outlined in policies. This alignment created a feedback loop